Lyle moved through the city like a ghost. Empty streets except for the cold biting wind, a few scattered scavengers, and the occasional flicker of neon signs that never fully lit. Above him, drones traced invisible lines overhead, delivering goods, scanning, and ignoring, yet logging, those moving around without the required debt chips. The system the U.E. had designed did not see him, not really. That was the point.

No one did.

He could've called himself lucky, if survival alone was enough to earn it. But Lyle knew better. Poverty did not just take money; it stole dignity first. The ability to stand in a room without apology, to ask for help without shame, to exist without being treated like a warning or a mistake. Here, in the shadow of the United Earth's "prosperity," that dignity was already gone for some.

Scarred. Negs. Nons. Scraps. Names as numerous as the towns under the U.E.'s umbrella. They were the people of no use: unfit for the war effort, useless in the construction of a utopia of indebted prosperity. Some suggested work camps. Others casually argued for public housing or assistance programs. The problem was simple. Camps cost money. Assistance costs money. And the U.E., just like their enemy the Nemicorp Conglomerate, cared about one thing more than anything else: the bottom line.

What ultimately happened to them was neither justice nor mercy. It was something quieter. The system did not sentence you to death. It simply declined to host your survival. Lyle had learned this early.

He kept moving, one careful step at a time, his boots scuffing the cracked pavement. Fighting off the absurd cold Ravenholt was dealing with that year. He searched his typical spots along with a few others of his societal ranking. Many of the dumpsters though had new locks, mandated by a new 'public safety' rule.

The city had a rhythm all its own, a once rebuilt promise of the future now decayed into a quiet pulse of neglect and absence. Shop windows glared with polished emptiness, advertising lives no one he knew could ever live. Streetlights hummed faintly, their light half-burnt out LED arrays, like the promises of the United Earth itself.

Hours had passed, though time had lost meaning long ago. Hunger clawed at him, but hunger was manageable. Hunger could be ignored, bargained with, endured. The new social contract tore people apart in quieter ways, stripping them of personhood long before it killed them. It demanded attention, recognition, that someone saw you and said you existed, that your life had value. In the eyes of the system, he did not exist. His life had no value.

The people around him moved like shadows. Some hunched over carts or bags, shuffling from one task to the next, speaking only when necessity forced it. A red-haired boy trying to pry the lock off a dumpster, Lyle noticed the scar on the back of his hand. Too young to be put into this life, where remaining unseen mandated survival.

He had seen what happened to those who did not learn. They simply disappeared. Sometimes suddenly, sometimes slowly. The United Earth did not need to kill you directly to erase you from the ledger. It just refused to care, and that refusal was enough. A little cold in winter, a stolen ration, a working heater with nowhere to plug it in. One day the person would be gone, and the record would show nothing more than natural causes.

A man leaned against a building, muttering to himself. Lyle ignored him. The man was old. His hair white and stringy, his coat patched with mismatched pieces of fabric. Lyle noticed the tremor in his hands, the echo of countless defeats: nights spent shivering alone, meals skipped so others could eat, every small indignity piled on until body and mind no longer protested. Then Lyle shuddered as he noticed he was looking at his reflection, something he tended to avoid of late along with other people.

This city, this United Earth, was built to be like that. It punished interdependence. It punished community. It punished care for the weak or poor, because shared labor and resources threatened consumption. People who relied on each other did not generate profit. People who were alone could be charged for everything. Every need, every minor inconvenience, every human connection that once existed for survival had been replaced with a ledger.

Lyle knew the patterns. He saw them every day having nothing but time to watch the world for what it truly was. Families separated for jobs, friends scattered across districts, neighborhoods dismantled for efficiency or taxes, seniors aging in silence, the poor chasing rent, hours, food. The system did not fail these people. It worked exactly as designed. Isolation was infrastructure. Shame was its tool. Every death was a subsidy to be exploited or thrown away.

He stopped, pressing his back against the cold wall of an abandoned building. His breath formed clouds in the air, drifting upward and disappearing. He looked at his hands, rough and scarred, a map of a life lived on the margins. There was no heroism here. No escape. The system would not chase him. It would not care if he disappeared tonight. To the war machines, corporate profits, and political optics, Lyle was irrelevant.

And so he walked. Always forward. Always quiet. Always invisible.

But even that had its limits. Even shadows could be tripped over. Even ghosts could be found. He had felt the cold that was not winter, the hunger that was not satisfied with food, the loneliness of being an outcast. It was a presence, a pressure, a force that waited patiently, quietly, until a body and mind gave out. That was the system's true gift. Not violence. Not cruelty. Not punishment. Patience. It waited until survival itself became impossible. You either gave in and put yourself back into the system the U.E. had designed, or you simply ceased to be.

Night had fallen, a black so dense it pressed down on the city. Streetlights flickered and buzzed; some sputtered out entirely, leaving patches of darkness where shadows pooled like water. Lyle moved slowly, each step deliberate. His body ached, he was done walking to stay warm for the day. Not enough calories found in the few table scraps he procured, the stash he had built up for this longer than normal winter, already gone.

A playground loomed, empty except for rusted swings swaying in the wind. He remembered laughter once filling this space as he swung with his friends, back when hope was still tangible. Now only echoes remained, distant and faint, swallowed by a gentle squeak of the swing now only pushed by the wind. There was no one to share a moment with. No one to ask for help. No one noticed when life became unbearable. Sure there was an app for that, but apps cost money, they cost debt. There was always an app for that… but never a person, a living soul.

His coat was thin, patched with threadbare pieces that barely kept the wind at bay. Fingers stiff and pale, he considered shelters, other streets, small kindnesses he might find. But all of it was a gamble. Shelters had rules, limited space, and oversight that reminded you were never truly free. Once the

shelter reached the number of people they would be paid to help that day, the caring ended. No, tonight he would sleep where he could, where no one would question his presence, where no one would question if he belonged, where the system would not notice if he did not wake again.

He found a corner in a closed-down convenience store, metal shutters rattling in the wind. Curling against cold concrete, he felt his heartbeat, slow and uneven. He knew not to fall asleep directly on cold concrete like this, to have a piece of cardboard between you and it. Breath came in short bursts, forming tiny clouds that vanished quickly in the winter winds. There was a bitter beauty to it: the world continued even while ignoring him completely.

He thought of pride and shame, the quiet war the system waged. It was not about punishment. It was about erasure. Every slight, every silent refusal chipped away at the self. People stopped asking for help, stopped noticing each other, stopped believing they mattered. The system did not need to lift a hand. People punished themselves. Disappeared long before the world took notice.

He traced the faint outlines of buildings, windows dark and empty. Somewhere inside, people ate, watched holo-screens. That was the real design. Not violence. Not immediate cruelty. But slow, silent neglect, accounted for as natural causes. A quiet patience making survival optional, disappearance inevitable.

He closed his eyes, trying to think of things no longer within reach: old friends, the smell of warm bread, the sound of someone calling his name without hesitation. Of someone even remembering his name. Memories were sharp and sweet, and painful. He drew his knees closer, arms wrapped around himself. The cold gnawed, but the weight in his chest was heavier. Loneliness, erasure, he had carried them for years.

Would anyone ever notice? Authorities? The news? People walking past on brighter days? And if they did, would it matter? He had learned slowly, painfully: this world had no place for him. The system did not care. Survival was a privilege, and he had been denied it.

He shivered, closing his eyes against cold and inevitability. The night stretched on. Wind cut through him. Every breath, harder than the last. Somewhere deep inside, the final layers of himself folded inward, dissolving quietly. He did not struggle. There was no point. The system would not intervene. The city would not mourn. He was becoming invisible in the truest sense.

By morning, the street would be empty and cold, as countless times before. The system would log nothing remarkable. The world would move on.

Lyle exhaled one last breath, one last cloud of vapor that disappeared into the dark, letting darkness take him fully, letting cold seep to every corner. In quiet obscurity, he disappeared.

Morning arrived pale and gray. The streets were quiet, humming only with distant traffic and metallic clangs from empty construction sites. Lyle’s typical corner was empty. A thin frost clung to the pavement; his coat lay crumpled, a small, forgotten shadow of a person who had been there hours before. No one stopped. No one asked. No one noticed. The city moved on.

Somewhere high above, holo-screens flickered advertisements, promising warmth, comfort, security, and happiness for those who could afford it. The words washed over the city in constant rhythm, carrying no meaning for people who could not reach them.

Down below rabbit fur covered boots crunched against the snow, a patchwork coat kept out the cold. The boy was twelve. Lanky, red-haired, arms too thin for his coat, wandering the empty streets in the early morning light. Hands covered in lazily crafted mittens of old socks and fur. He was wandering down the alleyways, looking for things he could use, curious about shadows, he saw the man.

Lyle lay half-buried under frost, coat stiff, skin pale against cracked concrete. The boy crouched closer, heart thumping. Eyes tracked the hand, fingers curled against cold, scarred, networked with old burns and shallow cuts, each line telling stories of a world the boy had only begun to understand. His eye was drawn to the one scar the old man had, similar to his own.

His own hand itched, remembering the faint scar on the back of his hand, where he had removed his debt chip. A memory of erasure, of walking free because he no longer belonged to the system’s numbers. Lucky then. The scar remained. Now, seeing this hand, he realized the man had done the same years before. The man had removed himself quietly, leaving only traces.

The wind carried a faint whispered harshness to it. The boy shivered, not from cold, but from the weight of the moment. He looked at the man’s closed eyes and frozen tears. He understood a truth shaping him forever: some people vanish without notice, scandal, or record. Their absence is still a presence. A warning. A lesson.

He touched the scarred hand lightly, not from fear, but reverence. The frost bit, and he withdrew his fingers quickly, holding the knowledge close. This world had its rules. Its invisible victims. And now he had seen one.

“Look, I don’t know what to say here, “ as the red-haired boy got to his knees holding his hands together. “I don’t know much about how to do this, or what to say… But I think if I don't say something here nobody will. So if something up there is watching please guide this old man to somewhere warm, somewhere he has enough food to eat, and a good friend to talk to... umm, well like I said I’m not good at this so… like amen or whatever it is that you’re supposed to say.”

Then he stood, shoulders straightening, stepping back, wiping the tears from his eyes before they could freeze. Elsewhere in the city, life continued oblivious. The United Earth ticked through morning routines, counting the living, ignoring the dead. The boy turned forward, carrying the memory of that hand, that scar, that quiet resistance. He did not yet know what he would do with it, but he would remember.